detainment—inquiring, they were told only that they were being held "at His Majesty's pleasure." Thinking themselves the world's foremost experts on nuclear physics—and convinced that any American bomb effort could not possibly have surpassed the German one, since German physics was superior—they hatched wild schemes to alert the press of their plight, to escape to Cambridge and see their colleagues there who (they presumed) were desperate to consult them on their knowledge of nuclear matters. They even spoke matter-of-factly about their fates being decided personally by the "Big Three," Truman, Churchill, and Stalin, who were meeting in Potsdam at the time. Some managed to convince themselves that their association with the Nazis would not be held against them personally, and that they would be able to use their status as elite physicists to escape to Argentina and start new lives.

Finally, after weeks in luxurious captivity, the bubble burst. On the evening of August 6, 1945, just before dinner, Major Rittner, the British military intelligence officer in charge of Farm Hall, quietly took Otto Hahn aside and told him that the Americans had dropped an atomic bomb on Hiroshima. "Hahn was completely shattered by the news," wrote Rittner:

> He felt personally responsible for the deaths of hundreds of thousands of people, as it was his original discovery which had made the bomb possible. He told me that he had originally contemplated suicide when he realized the terrible potentialities of his discovery.… With the help of considerable alcoholic stimulant he was calmed down and we went down to dinner where he announced the news to the assembled guests. As was to be expected, the announcement was greeted with incredulity.

"I don't believe a word of the whole thing," said Heisenberg upon hearing the news. "I don't believe it has anything to do with uranium." Hahn jeered, "If the Americans have a uranium bomb then you're all second raters. Poor old Heisenberg." After they heard the BBC report the news in great detail later that night, Heisenberg and the others accepted the truth: they had been beaten.

Over the next few days, Heisenberg attempted to work out how his project had fallen so far behind; his fumbling calculations show that he had never really understood how to even build a bomb in the first place, though he had certainly thought he'd understood it. And the bickering of the other